MANMOHAN SINGH 1932-2024

THE QUIET REFORMER

Manmohan Singh, prime minister of India between 2004 and 2014 and seen as the architect of India's economic liberalisation, passed away on December 26 at the age of 92. His journey from a modest upbringing in Gah, Punjab (now in Pakistan), to becoming India's 14th prime minister is a testament to his resilience, intellect and unwavering commitment to public service. Manmohan's legacy is etched in India's transformation from a struggling post-colonial economy to an emerging global powerhouse. Few people knew Manmohan Singh as intimately as distinguished economist **MONTEK SINGH AHLUWALIA**, who had worked with him when he was finance minister and then later when he was prime minister. In his book *Backstage: The Story Behind India's High Growth Years* published in 2020, Ahluwalia brings out key facets of Manmohan Singh's personality—with clarity and the authenticity of a confidant. Here are excerpts from Ahluwalia's book, paying tribute to Manmohan Singh's immense contribution to the nation's progress narrated with rare personal insights and candour:



HINDUSTAN TIMES

A LASTING BOND Economist Montek Singh Ahluwalia with former prime minister Manmohan Singh

ON MANMOHAN BEING MADE FINANCE MINISTER

I was commerce secretary when the new government was to be sworn in on June 21, 1991. I was pleasantly surprised to be called to a meeting at the PMO before the ceremony. Among those present was Dr Manmohan Singh, who had recently returned to India after spending three years at the South Commission in Geneva. He had been appointed chairman of the University Grants Commission and economic advisor to PM Chandra Shekhar. The PM designate P.V. Narasimha Rao had called us to discuss what he should say in his first broadcast to the nation, scheduled for the next day. With the economic crisis still raging, he had to give some indication of how it would be addressed.

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